

v3 register lock: no sword mythology, no parenthetical narrator asides, the corporation-spine threaded through every scene. The hum in Kyle's chest is an Atlas-program ghost living in corp infrastructure the corps have stopped watching. Sable's whole operation runs in the seams the corps abandoned. The Faraday cage is the only place ambient corp surveillance does not reach.

Pure-cool action: the cage going silent on Kyle's chest, the hood coming down, the chrysanthemum busker, the "thank you." No jokes during these. Humor lives in the regular sentences. Corp-spine is the constant pressure in the air.

Long-con misdirect maintained: avatar hypothesis is the leash, truth held in reserve, planted but not flagged for the reader on this read.

A Restless Mind

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Part I — Watching A Woman Pretend Not To Watch Him

The noodles were getting cold.

Kyle was watching a woman pretend not to watch him, and the noodles, in the meantime, were getting cold. The two facts were not related. The first was about the woman across the walkway. The second was about the broth's surface tension and the ambient air temperature at this particular slice of the Gray Zone at 21:43 on a Wednesday in March, eight hours and change after he had left Mrs. Chen's the night before. He had returned because he had said he would. The agreement was the contract. The contract was the bond. The bowl was hot when she set it down, the chip was on the counter at standard rate, and Kyle, by the time he was two bites in, had stopped pretending he was here for the noodles.

The woman across the walkway was eleven minutes into a stance she did not appear to have adjusted in any of those eleven minutes.

The rain came down at the angle the Arcturus atmospheric processors preferred — steep, efficient, redirected from somewhere that mattered to somewhere that did not — and it came off her hood in a clean sheet that said the coat was quality, the kind of quality that did not announce itself. The hood was up. The face was hidden. The posture was composed in the specific way that composure cost effort to maintain, which was the way professional composure always looked if you knew what professional composure was supposed to cost.

The Atlas array reached. The array found nothing. It was expecting one of several things — a chrome augmentation profile, a neural implant's electromagnetic signature, a brand-tagged piece of corporation hardware — and the array was very good at finding those, having been calibrated by NeoCortex specialists whose budget for calibration had been larger than the GDP of the Settled-Worlds municipality the NeoCortex board chair owned a vacation home in. The array did not find any of these on the woman in the hood. It found, instead, the shape of where these things would have been on

a person who had them — a negative space the array could detect but not resolve, which was either a person entirely unaugmented in a way that was so rare in this city as to be statistically interesting, or a person whose augmentations were so well-shielded that the shielding was the augmentation. The array was inclined toward the second. The array tended to be right.

Nobody stands still in the rain for eleven minutes unless the rain doesn't bother them or the job requires it.

Behind him, Mrs. Chen stirred the broth with a long-handled spoon that had lost its lacquer in three places and been re-gripped with electrical tape — the same spoon she had used for the four years he had been eating at this stall — and she said one word into the steam.

Húlijīng. Low. Mandarin. Not for him.

She said it the way a woman who had seen things named them — with the flat certainty of a diagnosis, not a warning. *Húlijīng*, fox spirit, a folklore figure that her mother had taught her out of a Hong Kong opera in 1991 and that Chen Wei-Lin had quietly carried across thirty years and three cities and three planets to deploy, tonight, into the steam of her stockpot at a woman who had been standing in the rain for eleven minutes pretending not to watch one of her customers. Naming was a kind of work she did. Naming did not require Kyle's response any more than the cleaver work did.

He set his chopsticks down across the bowl. He had heard Mrs. Chen mutter at the rain, at the Circuit boys who walked too close to her signage, at the atmospheric processors when they made the broth steam wrong. He had never, in four years, heard her name a person.

The catalogue had earned its weight.

The woman stepped under the awning.

The hood came back two centimeters. Not all the way. Just enough that the streetlight caught the shape of a face — high cheekbones, the dark of red hair beneath the rain hood, a jaw that did not quite belong to flesh in the

specific way that an extremely well-fabricated chrome jaw did not quite belong to flesh — and the array catalogued *attractive* the way the array catalogued anything: as a fact registered without commentary. Tall. Late thirties. Bone structure that had cost her nothing because she had been born with it and bone structure that had cost her something because the lower jaw was, on closer inspection at thirty-percent magnification courtesy of the ocular's passive zoom, not the bone structure she had been born with. The jaw was Hong Kong work, 2218, the year after a corporation pharmaceutical recall had taken a great many lower jaws off a great many people who had been taking the corporation pharmaceutical and who had been issued a settlement that, on average, paid for one new jaw of better quality than the one they had lost. Whether Sable's jaw was on that ledger or on a different one, Kyle did not know. He would, on inspection, come to suspect a different one.

He had not seen her face before tonight. He was not entirely sure he was supposed to be seeing it now.

Then she spoke.

Not loud. Not for Mrs. Chen. For him, across two meters of rain.

"Kyle."

Just the name. Level, unhurried, the tongue she had chosen to say it in the same tongue she used through the cracked terminal at the parts shop three blocks east — the modulated register, the older one, the voice he had been getting contracts in for two months and had not yet built a face for.

The match landed in his head before he had time to refuse it. Voice plus face.

Sable.

For two months — the cracked terminal at Otto's parts shop, the modulated voice, eleven contracts routed cleanly through a pipeline Otto did not log because Otto did not log anything and which the corporations could not monitor because the terminal at Otto's was a 2208 piece of equipment

running 2208 firmware that the corporations had stopped writing patches for in 2214. The contracts had been clean. The trust index had built. Kyle had built two centimeters of face under streetlight, and the rest was arriving now and fitting itself over the partial like a key into a lock she had already shown him.

He set the chopsticks down. He did not stand. He did not move his hands away from the counter. The left was already where Chorus would be in eight-tenths of a second; the right was already where the katana's draw would begin in three-tenths. He let her see him not move and let the not-moving be the answer to the question she had not asked yet.

She tilted her head — the smallest possible geometry of *come* — and Kyle, who now knew exactly who she was and was therefore in a worse strategic position than if he had not known, did the calculation a freelancer did when his fixer of two months showed up at his stall in person and said only his name.

If she wanted me dead, the angle from the doorway would already be open. If she wanted to ambush me, she would not have spoken. She is here for something the cracked terminal cannot carry. She is here because the room she lives in is not safe.

The chair scraped back.

He set a second chip on the counter beside the first and said it the way he said it every night, low and level.

"Standard rate."

Mrs. Chen's hand covered both chips without looking down, which was how she always took money from him when she thought he was about to do something she didn't approve of and had decided not to say so. The other hand kept the ladle moving in the stockpot. The stockpot had thirty-eight years of opinion about everything Kyle had ever done in its presence and continued to keep the opinion to itself, because the stockpot, unlike the corporations, understood that not every position needed to be enforced to be held.

He followed the woman into the rain.

His left hand stayed where Chorus would be. His right stayed where the katana's draw would begin. He did not stop tracking her three-quarter profile for the entire walk. She was already moving, deeper into the walkway's dark, and he fell in six feet behind her — far enough to read her, close enough that she knew he had chosen to come. The katana's weight shifted against his hip with each step, the way it always did on wet ground: a small correction, muscle memory now, Seo's blade finding its balance in him long after Seo had stopped being able to carry it himself.

Kyle did not know who she was, not really. He knew the shape of her competence the way you knew a locked door by the quality of the lock. The lock was very good. She had been standing in the rain for eleven minutes waiting for him specifically, and those two facts together were either a contract or a problem. In his experience they were usually both.

He was going to find out which.

Part II — The Walk

The Gray Zone at this hour was the Gray Zone at this hour. The roller doors of the closed shops were closed. The tier-six awning above the mochi cart was dripping in a perfectly continuous line off one corner where the rain had filled a depression in the cart's roof, the kind of detail the atmospheric processors produced without intending to. The cart was closed because the vendor had been short on his Carrion stall license six months running and had been told by Tien's predecessor — a man who had not been named Tien — that the next visit would be on the second of the month rather than the third. The cart had not opened since.

The recycler vent on the second block exhaled hot industrial breath across the walkway — paper-dry and chemical-sweet, the Gray Zone processing its own refuse through a Carrion-subsidary unit that had been on a single replacement filter cycle for eleven years because the corporation's quarterly cost-of-goods review had ruled the filter cycle "compliant within tolerances." Tolerances had been redefined three times in those eleven years. Each redefinition had stretched. Kyle held his breath for two steps on instinct. Old facility reflex. He had been fifteen at the facility. He had walked through worse vents on worse breath, vents the NeoCortex Atlas program had run their own refuse through, on a contract the corporation had not bothered to file because filing it would have meant naming what the refuse was.

The Pinnacle Security IronSentry drone hung at the third-block junction, its sensor array cycling through the standard sweep at the standard interval — a 2218 model running 2218 firmware in 2226 because the Gray Zone's nominal landlord had been on a service contract with Pinnacle that had auto-renewed without the quarterly subscription Pinnacle had introduced in 2222 to gate the firmware patches. The landlord had not noticed the line item until 2225. By then the drone had been running known-vulnerable firmware for three years, and the parts of the city that paid attention to such things had built their movement patterns around the drone's blind spots, and Sable — who was the parts of the city that paid attention to such things, the whole of those parts in a tan coat in the rain — walked through the junction

at exactly the interval the drone's sweep could not flag, and the drone did not flag her. She had timed the approach or she had known the interval, and either answer said the same thing about how long she had been thinking about this particular walk. Kyle filed it. He filed everything. The NeoCortex ran hot in the rain, the implant's temperature regulation working harder than it should have been, a low warmth behind his left ear that he had learned to read the way a pilot read engine noise — not yet a problem, a thing to monitor.

The relay station resolved out of the dark at the end of the block. Wartime construction. Arcturus Communications had built it in 2199 during a brief and ill-fated experiment with municipal broadband partnership the corporation had withdrawn from in 2203 to focus on *higher-margin verticals*, which had meant in practice that Arcturus had stopped serving the people who needed the relay station and started serving the people who could pay around it. The station had been abandoned, leased to a shell company, leased onward, and had eventually come into Sable's hands by way of an inheritance ledger the heirs of the previous owner had not been informed of. Sable had used it once before tonight. The kind of building that became invisible through its own explanation: *it is a relay station, it is empty, there is nothing here worth stopping for*. Sable had selected the station from the inventory of buildings the corporations had stopped looking at, and the corporations had stopped looking at quite a lot of buildings.

She produced a key. Brass-gasketed. The gasket was the tell: standard keys did not need that seal. She turned it in a lock recently oiled, and the door opened on hinges recently oiled too. She stepped in. The dark inside was different from the dark outside — denser, absolute, the rain suddenly absent as a sound. She held the door.

Kyle read the held door the way he read everything: *she needs you inside, she needs you inside willingly, she needs you to make the choice yourself*.

He stepped through.

Part III — The Cage

The door closed behind him.

And the hum in his chest, the low electromagnetic signature that had lived in the implant's background like a second heartbeat for eleven years and had been there so long he had stopped noticing it the way you stopped noticing the sound of your own blood —

— went silent.

Kyle stopped walking.

He stood in the dark of a building he did not know with a woman he had only just learned the face of, and he listened, for the first time in eleven years, to the inside of his own chest. There was nothing in it. There was his heartbeat. There was his breath. There was the small mechanical pulse of the modified cardiac regulator running its scheduled diagnostic. There was the array's normal background rhythm.

There was no hum.

Eleven years.

He had been sixteen when they finished the installation. He had been sixteen when the harmonic had become part of him. He had not, until now, known it was not part of him.

So. That.

He found the equipment rack by feel — the old kind, bolted to the floor, steel, the bolts themselves worn smooth from decades of hands checking them. He sat on its edge. He did not reach for the katana. He sat with his hands on his knees and waited for whatever came next.

The hood came down.

Red hair. Loose braid. One strand against her cheekbone that had never stayed. The ocular implants — black, machined, the aperture rings that made a small sound when she shifted focus, the sound he had stopped noticing through two months of cracked-terminal audio and had just now, in this room, in this silence, identified as *her* — adjusted once as she looked at him. He had talked to this voice every Tuesday and Friday for two months. He had built a contract file, a behavioral profile, a trust index. The rest of her face arrived now and fit itself over what he had built.

She watched him have it. The implants did not adjust again.

Then: "If it is not looking through your eyes, it is interpreting your senses."

The voice was the same. Level, unhurried, the voice that had given him eleven operational briefings in two months.

"Either way — the moment you recognize me, it knows we are meeting. So I needed you to read me as a stranger." A pause that was not hesitation. "I needed you to choose to follow someone you did not know."

Kyle looked at the floor. The concrete was old, marked with the ghost-outlines of equipment that had stood here for decades and been removed. He thought about eleven years of the harmonic he had catalogued as ambient, as background, as *self*.

He thought about what it meant that it was not self.

He thought about whether it had been keeping him running or simply watching him run, and understood that he did not know, and understood further that this was a thing he should have asked a long time ago and had not asked because the asking had its own kind of answer.

"I do not like," Sable said, "being some non-human's puppet."

Flat. The way she said *the risk premium is already factored in*. A thing stated, not performed. She let it sit.

Then: "I can triangulate its physical position. Three locations. Three readings of surveillance traffic against your implants. I have placed the nodes. I need you outside this room behaving exactly as you behave."

Kyle looked up. The implants were still. The aperture locked.

"I need you to not change."

He considered what it meant to agree.

The hum had been there for eleven years and he had not known it was there, which meant it had been with him in every contract, every room, every choice he had believed was his. Agreeing to help locate it was not a neutral act. He sat with it for three seconds, which was longer than he usually needed.

"All right."

"Six blocks. We walk. You behave exactly as you behave. I watch the nodes. The thing watching through you watches with you, and what it does not yet know is that we have placed listening posts on the routes it expects. When we walk past them, the contrast between what your implant is broadcasting and what the nodes are receiving will give me its position. Three reads. Three locations. Then we will know where it lives."

"And then."

"Then we will know where it lives."

She did not elaborate. There was nothing yet to elaborate to. The avatar hypothesis was the cleanest reading of the data they had, and she had built it carefully across the past four days, and the hypothesis was the working frame: that the thing wanted Kyle's hardware as a body, that it had been studying his array for the eleven years it had been resident, that the contracts had been the study. The hypothesis was the kind of hypothesis you formed when you were short on information and afraid, and Sable was the kind of operator who built her working frame from what she had even when what she had was less than what she wanted. The hypothesis was

provisional. The hypothesis was, on her quiet private file, more provisional than she had let Kyle see, because Sable had built her career on not letting her clients see the parts of her files that were the most provisional. The provisional was where the actual money lived.

She handed him a small object. Round, dense, the size of a coin and the weight of a much larger coin. He took it without looking at it.

"In your pocket. It will activate when we leave the cage. You will not feel it. You will not need to. Behave."

He put it in his coat pocket.

She put the hood back up. She opened the door.

The hum came back as he crossed the threshold — not announcing itself, not gradually fading in, just *there*, the way it had been there for eleven years, and Kyle, for the first time in eleven years, was aware of it as a foreign presence. He registered the difference and walked out into the rain behind Sable and did not change his stride, his shoulders, his breathing, or the angle at which he carried the katana on his back, because Sable had asked him not to change and the discipline was the discipline and the discipline did the work the discipline had been asked to do.

The thing in his chest came with him.

It did not, as far as he could tell, suspect.

Part IV — Three Reads

One: The Market

Six blocks east-northeast.

The wet market was still running because the wet market always ran — it did not close for rain, did not close for cold, had not closed for the three-day curfew two years ago when an Arcturus security audit had locked down the sector and had simply moved two stalls deeper under the corrugated overhang and continued. Forty-seven vendors at the entry, maybe half still active at this hour, the rest packing or pretending to. Fish smell under rain smell under the chemical-sweet exhaust of the block's overtaxed recycler. The corporation that ran the recycler had been cited eight times in the last decade for emissions exceeding the buffer-zone standard, had paid the fines in each cycle, had filed the fines as a cost of doing business, and had continued to overrun the standard because the fines were cheaper than the equipment upgrade. The NeoCortex reached and found the familiar texture of the world — signal density, movement profiles, the low electromagnetic fingerprint of the Grid — and the hum was back, the same hum, and he registered it now the way you registered a footstep behind you.

There it is. Still there.

The two men were at the fourth stall.

One had a fish cart. The other wanted it.

Kyle read the situation in the time it took to take two steps. The man with the cart had a split lip already bleeding into his beard. The other was holding a length of rebar at his side in the loose way of someone who had picked it up and not yet decided what for. The aunt at the neighboring stall was yelling in Mandarin — the specific register of a woman who had seen this particular fight before and was yelling not because she thought it would stop anything but because silence would have meant she had accepted it.

The rain came down and took the blood — fish blood from the overturned bucket at the cart's base, man blood from the lip — into the gutter at the same rate, indifferent to the distinction.

This was not Kyle's fight. The discipline included the discipline of knowing which fights were yours. This was not one of his. The corporations had built the world this man and the man with the rebar were standing in, and the corporations would not be there when the fight finished, and the discipline of Kyle's that mattered tonight was the discipline of locating where the corporations could be reached, not where their work had landed.

His stride did not change. Sable's didn't either. Her right hand was in the tan coat pocket and had been since they left the relay station, and it was not a weapon she was holding.

The man with the rebar did not use it. The man with the cart did not run. They stood in the rain and ran out of whatever had been sustaining the fight — not resolution, not decision, just the body's unwillingness to continue — and the man with the cart took the cart, and the man with the rebar sat down on the curb in the rain and put the rebar across his knees and looked at nothing.

The aunt said one more thing, sharp and final, the period at the end of a sentence she had been writing for years, and went back to her stall.

The market continued. Kyle and Sable continued.

Somewhere in Sable's coat pocket the first node was reading, and whatever it was reading was the business of something that had been living in Kyle's chest for eleven years, and Kyle walked and did not change.

Two: Tier 1 At Three

The residential block came up on them slowly, the way Tier 1 blocks always did — not a threshold but a gradation, the market's corrugated overhangs giving way to poured concrete faces and the narrower dark of streets that had not been designed for anything except the people who lived on them. The NeoCortex registered the shift: lower signal density, the Grid's

texture thinning to something older and less maintained, the Arcturus monitoring grid running at a lower density here because the per-capita advertising revenue did not justify the bandwidth. The hum adjusted with it. Smaller, he thought, and then corrected himself. Not smaller. *More precise.* As if the reduced interference gave it room to sharpen. As if the thing had been waiting for the corporation noise to thin out so it could listen better.

The couple was on the third stoop from the corner.

A thermal cloth over the bowl, the iridescent kind that kept heat in but cost nothing, the seams repaired twice at least. The man had noodles on his chin and the woman wiped it with a folded napkin — not looking at him, looking at the middle distance the way you looked when a thing was so practiced it had stopped requiring attention — and the man kept eating. No thank you. The thank you had been said ten thousand times and was now in the gesture itself.

Kyle filed it. The NeoCortex did not file it. He did. There was a difference, and he had only recently started to understand what the difference meant.

Sable walked at his left, her right hand still in the coat pocket, the second node reading, and she did not look at the couple.

The child came from the cross-street at speed, wheeled cart clattering over the uneven seam where two paving generations met — the old ferrocrete and the newer composite, both cracked, neither replaced because the corporation that had been responsible for the sector's paving had withdrawn from sector maintenance contracts in 2218 after a Series E investor letter had identified residential infrastructure as a *cost center incompatible with portfolio growth*. The cart was recycler tubing, bundled and bungee-corded, and it was older than the child by enough years that the frame had been re-welded at two joints. The child navigated around them without slowing, without looking up, the route memorized or improvised so quickly it amounted to the same thing.

Gone.

The old man was at the streetlight — the one that flickered in the specific rhythm of a ballast that had been failing for as long as Kyle had been in this part of the city — and the chess board on his folding table was worn smooth at the corners where his thumbs had rested for however many years it had taken to make the lacquer disappear. He was playing himself. He moved a rook, considered the result from the other side of the board, and looked dissatisfied, which meant he was honest about it.

The two teenagers were under the broken awning — the one with the bent strut that had been bent since before Kyle moved into The Pivot, which meant it had been bent for at least four years and would be bent for four more because fixing it required someone to have filed a request with the property-management corporation and someone in the property-management corporation to have read it, and the property-management corporation's request system had been engineered, in 2222, to absorb tickets at a rate that exceeded its processing rate, which meant the tickets accumulated and the tickets aged out and the awning stayed bent. One cigarette. Passed left. Not speaking. The comfortable silence of people who had run out of urgent things to say and found something better on the other side of it.

Sable went still.

Not a pause. Not the stillness of a person checking their footing or reading a sign. The stillness of a person who had seen something in data and needed three seconds to understand what they were seeing.

Kyle did not look at her.

He looked at the old man move his bishop and immediately regret it. He looked at the thermal cloth on the couple's bowl shift as the man reached for the napkin himself this time, belatedly, too late to be the gesture it had been when she did it. He counted the seconds by the flicker of the streetlight, which was reliable in its unreliability.

One.

Two.

Three.

Then she was walking again, the same pace, the coat pocket still, the ocular implants making their small sound as they adjusted to the distance ahead.

She said nothing. He did not ask. The block continued behind them, and the block did not know that anything had shifted, and Kyle walked and catalogued and felt the hum sharpen again at the base of his sternum, and whatever Sable had read in the node she was carrying now like a stone she had decided not to put down.

Three: The Chrysanthemum Courtyard

Ten blocks east.

The courtyard opened between two buildings that had collapsed toward each other and stopped, the way exhausted things stopped — not falling, not standing, somewhere between. Someone had run cables across the gap and strung lights, the small kind, and the rain moved through them without caring. The ferrocrete planters were salvaged, four of them, mismatched in height and diameter, arranged with the logic of someone who had thought about where the light would be in the morning.

Chrysanthemums.

Real ones. White and rust and one the color of old brass. The petals held the rain's weight the way petals did when they had been tended — not breaking, adjusting.

The buildings around the courtyard were on the Arcturus property registry as *partial-collapse* — *pending demolition*, which was the same designation Arcturus had been applying to buildings since 2218 on the working theory that the designation was cheaper than either demolition or repair and rendered the buildings invisible to the corporation's own asset-management algorithms, which suited the corporation because the corporation did not want to look at the buildings and did not want anyone else to look at them either. The gardener was a woman named Joan who lived on the third floor of the western building and had been growing chrysanthemums in the

courtyard since 2219, when the eastern building had partially come down in the spring storms and Joan had decided, between one Wednesday and the next, that the rubble was an opportunity. She had hauled the planters in herself. She was, on this particular night, asleep two floors above the courtyard. She did not know her garden was about to be the third reading in a triangulation. She would not, ever, find out. The garden would continue. So would Joan.

The busker was at the far end on an overturned crate. The instrument was across his knees — sanxian, possibly, or something older than the word he had for it, three strings and a long neck and a body that had been repaired at the shoulder joint with what looked like epoxy and conviction.

The piece was slow.

It was in a key that did not have a name in any register Kyle's implant carried, which meant it was either older than the implant's references or simply outside them, and the sound moved through the courtyard and did not echo the way it should have — the collapsed walls doing something to the acoustics that produced instead a kind of presence, the music occupying the space rather than bouncing off it.

Kyle stopped walking.

Sable took two more steps before she understood he was not beside her.

He heard the small sound the ocular implants made when they adjusted — the aperture tightening as she looked at him, read him, recalculated. He was not looking at her. He was looking at the busker, who was not looking at either of them, whose attention was entirely on the middle distance above the strings in the way of a person for whom the playing and the listening had become the same act.

The hum in Kyle's sternum was there. It was always there now — he would always know it was there now — but the music was also there, and for the length of one song they occupied the same space without canceling each other. The corporation algorithms that had spent the last decade trying to classify and tag and monetize every possible piece of audio that passed

through the city had no entry for the key the busker was playing in, no entry for the song, no entry for the instrument's particular grain — and the absence of the entry was the reason the song could happen in the courtyard at all. The corporations could only sell what they could classify. What they could not classify, they left alone, because leaving alone was cheaper than the classification work, and the things they had left alone were now where most of the city's actual life lived.

Sable's hand moved in the coat pocket. The third node reading. The rain came down.

The song ended the way things ended when they had been played correctly — not stopping, arriving.

Kyle reached into his coat pocket and produced what was there: forty credits, the same number he had left on Mrs. Chen's counter, which was not a decision he had made consciously and which he did not examine now. He set them on the crate beside the busker.

The busker did not look up.

Kyle turned.

Sable was watching him with the aperture locked, the expression she had when the variables had resolved into something she had not expected and was deciding whether to name.

She did not name it.

"That's three," she said, very quietly, and the ocular implants made their small sound and she looked away, at something only the node showed her, at coordinates that were now coordinates rather than a search.

Kyle walked.

She walked beside him.

Neither of them said anything about the garden or the forty credits or the key the piece had been in, and the busker behind them began, without

pause, to play something else.

Part V — The Thanks

She stopped at the courtyard's western edge where the collapsed buildings gave way to open street.

The rain had not changed. It was not going to change until the processors decided it had served its purpose, and it had not served its purpose yet — the night's projected precipitation was still 11mm short of the Arcturus seasonal target and the processors were running the deficit down at the rate the climate-product roadmap had specified.

She turned — not fully, not the full rotation of a person turning to face someone, but the partial turn of a person who had decided to close a file while still holding it.

"I'll contact you when the timing is operational."

Flat, clean, the risk premium already factored in.

"We go together. My read, my call."

Not a question. Not a request.

Then: "Thank you."

Two words.

The kind that meant something had been agreed to that could not be un-agreed to, that the agreement itself had changed the shape of what came next.

She did not touch him. She did not bow. She turned west and walked, and the tan coat went with her into the rain, and Kyle stood at the courtyard's edge and watched her go for three seconds.

The chrome jaw, the array offered him on closing — for the file, because the array did not have a setting for *do not file* — had been fabricated at a

Hong Kong corporation medical-tourism facility in 2218. The bone underneath had been removed in the same surgery for reasons not in the public record. Sable was thirty-eight years old. She had been a fixer for fourteen years. Before that she had done something the public record did not name. Before that she had been a child somewhere the public record did not list. The picture remained partial. The picture, Kyle suspected, would remain partial. That was who Sable was. That was, in part, why he liked her.

Then he turned north.

The hum came back as he passed the last planter — the brass-colored chrysanthemum, the one holding the rain's weight without breaking — and settled into his sternum with the particular quality of something returning to its place. He registered it the way you registered the temperature of a room after a long phone call: the air had always been this temperature, you had simply been elsewhere for a while.

The street opened north toward The Pivot. The wet market's smell reached him from two blocks back, fish and rain and the recycler's exhaust, and somewhere behind him the busker continued to play something he did not have a name for in any register the implant carried.

Kyle walked.

The hum walked with him.

The bike was where he had left it, three blocks south of the noodle stall, the cover beaded with rain, the plate the one he had ridden down on. He started it. He rode the long way home through tier crossings he did not strictly need to make, because the long way home was where Kyle did most of his thinking, and tonight was a night he had something to think about.

He did not know who else knew that something had been resident in his chest for eleven years. He suspected the something knew. He suspected the something had known longer than he had.

The bike's headlight crossed the canyon between buildings the way the city's headlights crossed everything at this hour — moving, not arriving, the architecture of motion that the GLMZ had been built around once the corporations had decided that arrival was a service rather than a destination. The sky was the bruise again. A fifth VTOL was crossing it, going north. Kyle did not file the running lights.

He thought, briefly and without judgment, about what it had felt like in the cage. The silence. Eleven years.

He had no working theory yet for what to do with the information. The discipline did not provide a procedure for *something has been resident in your chest for eleven years without your permission*. The discipline provided procedures for *contracts, combat, negotiation, grief, and the receiving of unsolicited kindness from women who ran noodle stalls*. It did not provide a procedure for this. The discipline, Kyle had begun to understand, was something he was going to have to extend.

He had no idea, yet, what the extension was going to cost. He suspected he was going to find out.

The corporations had not built a procedure for this either. The corporations did not need to. The corporations had built the thing that needed the procedure and had not, in the building, included a procedure for living with it. That was the trick of the work the corporations did. They built. They did not maintain. The maintenance was the customer's problem. The customer, this evening, was Kyle.

Part VI — The Door Across The Hall

The bike's headlight crossed the alley wall at 03:54 and Kyle killed the engine before he turned in, coasting the last twelve meters on momentum because the engine cutting at the corner had been Seo's lesson and Kyle had not yet found a reason not to do everything Seo had taught him to do.

The rain had softened to mist by the time he got to West Town. The towers leaned in the way they did this far up; the canyon between The Pivot and the residential block across from it was just wide enough for a single VTOL to thread through if a VTOL had any business being this far down, which they didn't. The space above the alley was dark. The light came up from the windows, not down from the sky.

He kicked the stand down. He locked the wheel hub. He covered the plate. He walked the bike's stillness into the elevator and the elevator into the second floor and the second floor into the hallway, and his step hit the landing across from 2F at the angle he had not announced.

Pixel's door opened anyway. The third step from the top had been loose since the building changed hands in 2198 and would be loose until something structural made it a different problem. Pixel had memorized its sound the way other people memorized the sound of a partner's car in the driveway, which was not, on reflection, an analogy Kyle had ever spelled out to himself.

She was in a t-shirt over leggings, no shoes, the hallway's bad amber light catching the rim of two cups she was holding.

One in each hand. Not forceps tonight. Cups.

The steam was rising off both of them and Kyle could smell something herbal and lemon-bitter and could not name the specific plant because Pixel's tea cabinet was an ongoing research project he had stopped trying to keep up with roughly the third month he had lived across the hall from her. Most of what Pixel drank was gray-market — the kind of herb the

corporation pharmaceutical companies had attempted to standardize in 2222 and had, in the standardization, removed three compounds that had been doing most of the work in the original, which had created a small thriving sector of growers and importers who supplied the original to people who knew the difference. Pixel knew the difference. Pixel had a supplier. The supplier was, in this small specific way, also one of the people the corporations had pushed into the seam.

"You're back early."

He had not been gone long enough to be either early or late. *Early* was the kind of thing Pixel said when she had been listening for his step and the step had arrived and she had to put words on the relief without putting words on the relief. He took the cup she held out. It was hot. The handle was the side without the chip. She had given him the better cup, which was her version of saying something she did not intend to say aloud.

"Thanks."

"Mm."

They stood in their doorways across the hall and drank.

The hallway smelled faintly of someone's microwave dinner two doors down and faintly of Pixel's apartment behind her, which always smelled like solder flux and bergamot in proportions that should not have worked and somehow did. The cup in Kyle's hand was the temperature of *drink this slowly*, which suited him because he intended to.

She did not ask where he had been.

He did not tell her about the woman in the hood, or the three blocks east-northeast, or the relay station, or the cage, or the eleven years he had only just understood the meaning of, or the agreement he had said yes to without yet knowing whose room it would be consummated in, or the way the agreement had landed in his chest at exactly the angle the agreement had been designed to land.

Pixel did not ask. That was the entire shape of the convention they had built over four years across this hallway: she did not ask, and he did not tell, and the not-asking and the not-telling were the work that kept the friendship working. Other people's friendships were maintained by exchange. Theirs was maintained by editorial restraint. It was a luxury Kyle had not realized was a luxury until he had it.

She sipped her tea. He sipped his.

The mist outside was settling on the alley wall the way mist settled when the air below it was colder than the air above it, which was a meteorological condition the corporation weather processors three kilometers east had failed to predict for the fourth night running. Kyle had stopped checking the forecast roughly the same week he had stopped trying to keep up with Pixel's tea cabinet.

"Bird's still out."

She meant the upstairs neighbor's bird, which was a recurring data point in Pixel's running commentary on the building and which Kyle had never actually heard but which he understood to be a presence in Pixel's life the way the rain was a presence in the city.

"Yeah?"

"Sang twice this evening. New piece. I think it learned from the radio."

"Hm."

She watched him over the rim of her cup. Not with the focus she put on a fragment in his shoulder; with the looser focus she used when she was working on the larger question of whether he was, on a given night, all right.

He was, on this night, all right.

She read it. She did not need to confirm it. Her shoulders settled by a quarter inch and she sipped her tea.

"Tomorrow's going to be its own day," he said, eventually.

"They usually are."

He laughed. Quietly. One short exhalation through the nose, the kind of laugh that would not have been a laugh in any room but this hallway. It was the laugh of a man who had spent the evening agreeing to walk into a shielded room with a woman whose face he had not seen and whose name he did not know, and who had then learned that something had been living in his chest for eleven years, and who had walked home and found a cup of tea waiting in his neighbor's doorway, and who was finding the contrast funny in a way that did not need to be funny to anyone but him.

Pixel did not ask what was funny. Pixel never asked what was funny. The not-asking was the punchline.

He finished the tea. He handed her back the cup, handle-first, the way she handed him his when the convention ran the other direction. She took it. She bowed, a small bow, the bow of a friend acknowledging the closing of a transaction that had no exchange in it. He bowed back, smaller.

"Goodnight, Pixel."

"Goodnight, samurai."

She closed her door. He unlocked his.

He retired to 2F and sat on the edge of the bed in the dark for a while before he slept, because that was what the discipline asked for after evenings in which he had said yes to things he could not yet name, and because the bed was cold and the apartment was quiet and the tea was still warm in his chest and the world was, this night, fucked at a tempo he could ride.

Tomorrow's shielded room was tomorrow's shielded room.

Tonight had been a cup of tea and a closed door and a bird he had never heard.

The hum in his chest was the corporations' work, in a building the corporations had stopped looking at, in a sector the corporations had decided was not on the schedule, in a city the corporations ran without ever quite admitting they were running it. Kyle did not know yet who had been listening through the hum. He suspected he would. He suspected the listening had been listening longer than he had been alive.

He slept.

The thing in his chest did not.

It had not slept in eleven years.

The corporations had built the thing that did not sleep and had then forgotten where they had put it, and the forgetting was where the rest of the book was going to live.